IF IELTS STUDIO

IELTS Writing Language Bank

19 sections of sentence patterns and vocabulary for Academic Writing Task 1 (charts, tables, processes and maps) and Task 2 essays, with model sentences.

Original study material written by IF Academy.

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PART 1

Task 1 · Charts, tables, processes and maps

13 sections

Introduction: paraphrase the question

Rewrite the first sentence of the question in your own words. Do not copy it, and do not add an opinion.

shows	illustrates / compares / gives information about / depicts
the number of	the figures for / how many
the amount of	how much / the quantity of
the percentage of	the proportion of / the share of
between 2000 and 2020	over a 20-year period / from 2000 to 2020
in five countries	across five nations

EXAMPLE The bar chart compares the average number of hours that five age groups devoted to four leisure activities each week.

EXAMPLE The line graph illustrates how the number of visitors to four city attractions changed over a 20-year period.

Overview: the big picture (no figures)

Write 2 sentences. Give the main trend and the biggest difference or change. Never include numbers here.

Overall, it is clear that ...
The most striking feature is that ...
In general, X rose, whereas Y fell.
X remained the largest ... throughout the period.
By the end of the period, X had overtaken Y as ...
Process: Overall, the process consists of ... main stages, beginning with ... and ending with ...

EXAMPLE Overall, it is clear that coal and renewables moved in opposite directions, with renewables becoming the main source by the end of the period.

EXAMPLE Overall, the process is linear and can be divided into three main phases: preparation, extraction and packaging.

Trends: going up

Choose the verb or noun, then add an adverb or adjective to show how fast or how much.

rise / increase / grow	a rise / an increase / growth (in)
climb / go up	a climb (in)
surge / soar / rocket (very fast)	a surge (in)
double / triple / treble	a twofold / threefold increase
peak at / reach a peak of	a peak of
recover / rebound	a recovery

EXAMPLE Visitor numbers at the aquarium soared from 120,000 to 700,000.

EXAMPLE There was a dramatic surge in the share of renewables after 2008.

Trends: going down

fall / decline / decrease / drop	a fall / a decline / a decrease / a drop (in)
dip (small, short)	a dip (in)
plummet / plunge / collapse (very fast)	a slump / a collapse (in)
halve	fell by half
hit a low of / bottom out at	a low of

EXAMPLE Coal's share plummeted from 55% to just 6%.

EXAMPLE Passenger numbers collapsed in 2020, falling to between 2 and 3.1 million.

Trends: no change and ups and downs

remain stable / steady / constant / unchanged	stability
level off / plateau / stabilise (after a change)	a plateau
fluctuate (between ... and ...)	fluctuation(s)
hover around / stand at	—

EXAMPLE Attendance at the castle fluctuated narrowly between 350,000 and 400,000.

EXAMPLE The figure for the USA remained unchanged at 1%.

How much and how fast

Adverb + verb (rose sharply) or adjective + noun (a sharp rise).

Big: dramatically, significantly, substantially, considerably, sharply	dramatic, significant, substantial, considerable, sharp
Medium: noticeably, markedly, steadily	noticeable, marked, steady
Small: slightly, marginally, modestly, gradually	slight, marginal, modest, gradual
Fast or slow: rapidly, swiftly / gradually, steadily	rapid, swift / gradual, steady

EXAMPLE Spending on housing increased substantially, from 22% to 34%.

EXAMPLE There was a marginal rise in transport costs, from 14% to 15%.

Sentence patterns for data

Vary your sentences. Use at least three different patterns in one answer.

X + verb + adverb + from … to …	Wind power rose steadily from 2% to 33%.
There was a + adjective + noun + in X	There was a sharp fall in coal use after 2008.
X saw / experienced + a + adjective + noun	Spain saw a threefold increase in charging points.
X, which stood at …, + verb …	Tea sales, which stood at 12,000 cups in winter, fell to 7,000 in summer.
… , reaching / falling to …	Solar grew quickly, reaching 21% in 2025.
Having peaked at …, X then …	Having peaked at 42% in 2016, gas then declined.

Prepositions with numbers

Small words cost marks when they are wrong.

rose from 20% to 35%	the start and end points
rose by 15 percentage points	the size of the change
stood at / was at 40% in 2010	the level at one time
peaked at 42%	the highest point
a rise of 15%	noun + of + amount
a rise in sales	noun + in + topic

EXAMPLE Denmark's rate increased by 6 percentage points, from 32% to 38%.

Comparing and contrasting

Band 7+ answers compare, not just list.

X was the highest / the largest, followed by Y	the ranking
twice / three times as many … as	the size of a difference
X was slightly / far higher than Y	the degree of difference
whereas / while / in contrast / by contrast	two opposite facts
X overtook Y in 2015	one passes another
the gap between X and Y widened / narrowed	a changing difference
similarly / likewise / X followed a similar pattern	similar trends

EXAMPLE In 2016, Japan had more than three times as many charging points as any other country.

EXAMPLE Northgate grew steadily, whereas Eastport became gradually less busy.

Approximation and proportions

Use these when a figure falls between gridlines, or to vary the way you give percentages.

just over / just under / roughly / approximately / around	about the value
almost / nearly / well over / well below	near or far from a value
half (50%), a third (33%), a quarter (25%), a fifth (20%), a tenth (10%)	fractions
the vast majority (80%+), a large minority (40%+), a small minority (under 15%)	general proportions
accounted for / made up / comprised / represented	pie and table language

EXAMPLE Space heating accounted for exactly half of all household energy in 2000.

EXAMPLE Food made up almost a third of spending in 1995.

Process language

Use the passive (is + past participle) and sequencers. Describe every stage.

First / Initially / To begin with	the first stage
Next / Then / After that / Subsequently	middle stages
Once / After X has been ..., Y ...	joining two stages
At the following / next stage, ...	a new phase
Finally / In the final stage / The process ends when ...	the last stage
Passive verbs: is collected, is transported, is heated, is filtered, is packaged	what happens to the material
The resulting mixture / the remaining material / this by-product	referring back

EXAMPLE Once the olives have been washed, they are crushed into a paste.

EXAMPLE At the next stage, the mixture is heated in tunnels for two weeks.

Map language

Use the past simple and passive for changes; use 'to the north of' and similar for places. Compare the maps directly.

was replaced by / made way for	one feature changes into another
was demolished / removed / cleared	something disappears
was built / constructed / added / developed	something new appears
was extended / expanded / enlarged	something grows
was converted into / turned into	same building, new use
remained unchanged / was retained	no change
to the north / south / east / west of	position relative to another feature
in the north-east corner / along the southern edge	position on the map
opposite / next to / adjacent to / between	close positions
Overview: Overall, the area became more ... / the most noticeable change is ...	the big picture

EXAMPLE The factories in the south-west corner were demolished to make way for a housing estate.

EXAMPLE Overall, the island was transformed into a tourist destination, although the beach and much of the woodland remained unchanged.

Common Task 1 mistakes

Figures in the overview	Keep numbers for the body paragraphs.
Copying the question	Paraphrase with the words above.
Adding opinions or reasons ("because people became healthier")	Report only what the chart shows.
"increased of 10%"	increased by 10% / an increase of 10%
"the number of water"	the amount of water (uncountable)
Mixed tenses	Past for past dates; present for a process or no dates.
Listing every number	Group similar items and compare them.

PART 2

Task 2 · Essays

6 sections

Introduction: paraphrase and give your position

2 sentences: paraphrase the question, then answer it clearly.

It is often argued that … / Many people believe that …	paraphrase
This essay will argue that … / I firmly believe that …	opinion essays
While both views have merit, I would argue that …	discussion essays
This essay will examine the main causes of … and suggest some solutions.	problem and solution
In my view, the benefits of … clearly outweigh the drawbacks.	advantages and disadvantages

EXAMPLE It is often argued that governments should invest more in public transport than in roads. I firmly believe that this is the more sustainable choice.

Body paragraphs: topic, explain, example

Each body paragraph = one main idea + explanation + example + link back.

The main reason why … is that …	topic sentence
Another significant factor is …	second idea
This is because … / This means that …	explaining
As a result, … / Consequently, …	results
For example, … / A case in point is … / This is illustrated by …	examples
It is therefore clear that …	linking back

EXAMPLE A case in point is Copenhagen, where cycle lanes have encouraged almost half of commuters to travel by bike.

Balancing and hedging

Band 7+ writers acknowledge the other side and avoid over-general claims.

Admittedly, … / It is true that …, but …	conceding
Although / Even though …, …	contrast in one sentence
On the other hand, … / Conversely, …	the other view
tends to / is likely to / may / can	hedging
in many cases / to some extent / arguably	softening claims

EXAMPLE Admittedly, online learning can be less engaging; however, it gives rural students access to courses they could not otherwise take.

Conclusion

Restate your position and summarise your main points. Add nothing new.

In conclusion, … / To conclude, …	opening
Although …, I believe that …	balanced summary
For the reasons outlined above, …	summarising
It is therefore essential that …	final recommendation

EXAMPLE In conclusion, although technology brings undeniable convenience, I believe its effect on social skills deserves far more attention.

Formal word swaps

Replace informal words with academic ones.

get	obtain / acquire / receive
a lot of	a great deal of / a significant number of
big	substantial / considerable / significant
show	demonstrate / illustrate / indicate
think	believe / maintain / contend
bad / good	detrimental / beneficial
kids	children / young people
fix (a problem)	resolve / address / tackle

Common Task 2 mistakes

No clear position	State it in the introduction and repeat it in the conclusion.
Only answering half the question	Check every part of the question, especially in two-part questions.
Memorised, general examples	Use specific, realistic examples.
Contractions (don't, it's)	do not, it is
Overusing "firstly, secondly"	Vary your linking words.
Under 250 words	Aim for 270–300.